

How Family and Friends Can Help

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, spouses/partners, adult children, caregivers, friends

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

How Family and Friends Can Help

Why family and friends matter

Hearing loss affects conversations, routines, relationships, and shared activities. Family and friends can make a major difference. Small communication changes can reduce frustration and help the person with hearing loss stay included in everyday conversations.

Hearing loss is not selective listening

A person may hear well in one situation and poorly in another because listening depends on noise, distance, lighting, room acoustics, speaker voice, visual cues, and fatigue.

I can hear you, but I cannot understand you

Many adults with hearing loss can hear that someone is talking but cannot clearly understand the words. Shouting usually does not solve the problem and may distort speech. Clear speech, facing the listener, reduced noise, and rephrasing are often more helpful.

What not to do

- Do not speak from another room
- Do not turn away while talking
- Do not shout
- Do not repeat the same unclear word over and over
- Do not say "never mind"
- Do not assume hearing aids fix every situation

What helps most

- Get attention first
- Face the listener
- Speak clearly
- Move closer

- Reduce background noise
- Rephrase when needed
- Speak one at a time
- Write down important details
- Be patient and respectful

Involve family in hearing care when appropriate

Some adults benefit from bringing a communication partner to audiology appointments. The person with hearing loss should decide who they want involved.

Key Takeaway

Communication improves when family and friends face the listener, speak clearly, reduce background noise, rephrase rather than saying "never mind," and support hearing technology without criticism.

References

American Academy of Audiology. (2006). Guidelines for the audiologic management of adult hearing impairment. <https://www.audiology.org/practice-guideline/guidelines-for-the-audiologic-management-of-adult-hearing-impairment/>

American Speech-Language-Hearing Association. (n.d.). Aural rehabilitation for adults. <https://www.asha.org/practice-portal/professional-issues/aural-rehabilitation-for-adults/>

Kamil, R. J., & Lin, F. R. (2015). The effects of hearing impairment in older adults on communication partners: A systematic review. *Journal of the American Academy of Audiology*, 26(2), 155-182. <https://doi.org/10.3766/jaaa.26.2.6>

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Workbook 7: Family Communication Plan

Related article: [How Family and Friends Can Help](#)

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Workbook: Family and Friends Communication Plan

Who are my main communication partners?

- Spouse or partner
- Children
- Grandchildren
- Friends
- Coworkers
- Caregivers
- Healthcare providers
- Community members

What I want others to understand

- I can hear speech but do not always understand the words
- I hear better when I can see the speaker's face
- Background noise makes listening much harder
- I miss more when people speak from another room
- Shouting does not always help
- Rephrasing helps more than repeating the same words
- Written information helps me remember important details
- I want to be included

What helps me most

- Say my name before speaking
- Face me when speaking
- Move closer
- Speak clearly
- Do not shout
- Do not speak from another room

- Reduce background noise
- Rephrase when I miss something
- Speak one at a time
- Write down important details

One thing I wish my family or friends understood is:

One communication habit we want to change is:

One communication habit we want to build is: